

Organization

Dr. Christian A. Mahringer

TUM School of Management, Campus Heilbronn



Course agenda

Date	Main theme
13.04.2026	Definitional basics of organization
20.04.2026	Formal organizational design
27.04.2026	Organization and environment
04.05.2026	Strategic organization design
11.05.2026	Technology and organization
18.05.2026	Information technology, AI, and organization
01.06.2026	Informal organization

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08.06.2026	Informal organization
15.06.2026	Dynamic perspectives on organizing
22.06.2026	Guest lecture, Felix Ehrenfels, mmmake
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17.07.2026	Review and wrap-up

Session 12

Trends in organizational design: Learning Scrum, Design Thinking, and OKR

What you should be able to do after this and last week's session

Learning goals

- You can assess whether a form of organizing is new.
- You are familiar with recent trends in organizational design.
- You know the pros and cons of central organizational designs



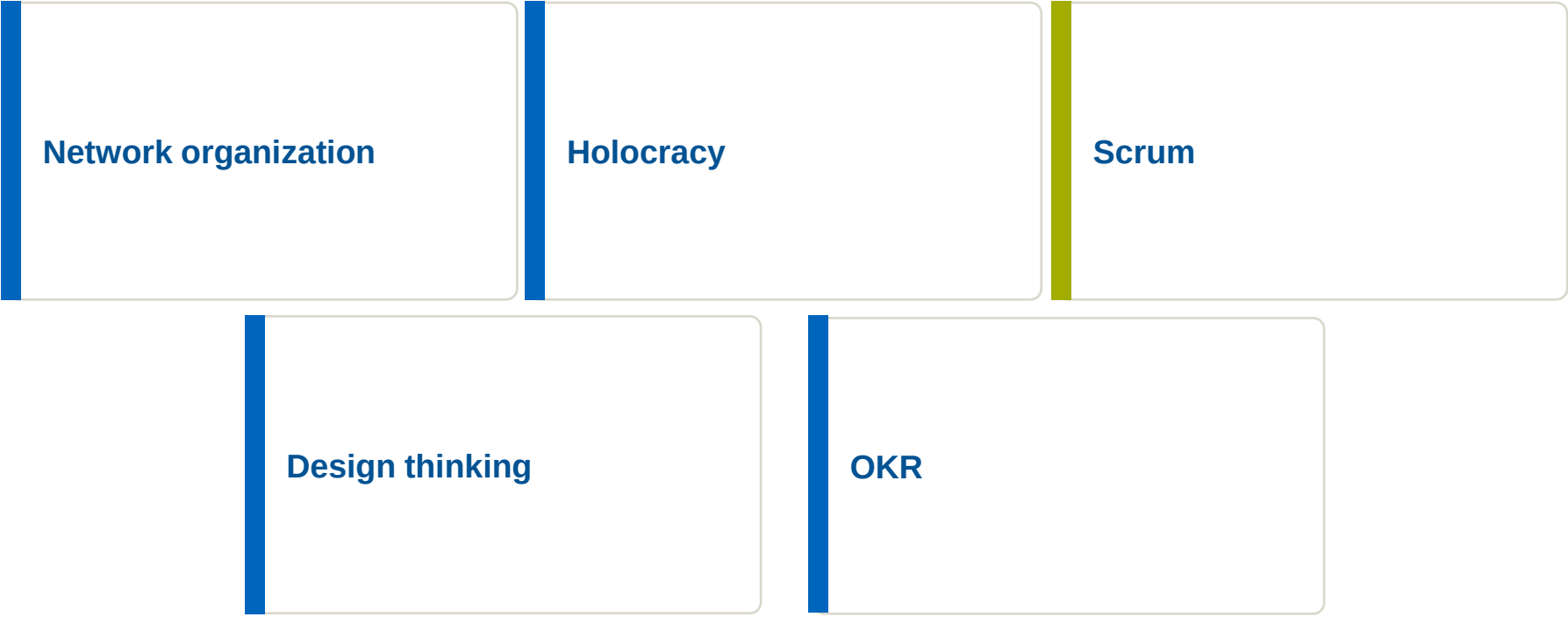
Image source: ChatGPT

Network organization

Example: Consulting firm “Eden McCallum”

- Client problem is defined by an internal partner
- Experts are selected from a large external consultant network
- Temporary project team is assembled around the task
- Team dissolves after project completion
- New projects use new expert combinations
- Capability comes from accessing distributed expertise
- Value lies in orchestration, not permanent hierarchy

Modern organizational forms



The diagram consists of five rectangular boxes arranged in two rows. The top row contains three boxes: 'Network organization' (left), 'Holocracy' (middle), and 'Scrum' (right). The bottom row contains two boxes: 'Design thinking' (left) and 'OKR' (right). Each box has a vertical bar on its left side: blue for 'Network organization', 'Holocracy', 'Design thinking', and 'OKR'; and green for 'Scrum'. All boxes have a thin grey border and rounded corners.

Network organization

Holocracy

Scrum

Design thinking

OKR

Scrum

Scrum structures task completion at the team level

Roles

Product Owner
Scrum Master
Developers

Events

Sprint Planning
Daily Scrum
Sprint Review
Sprint Retrospective

Artefacts

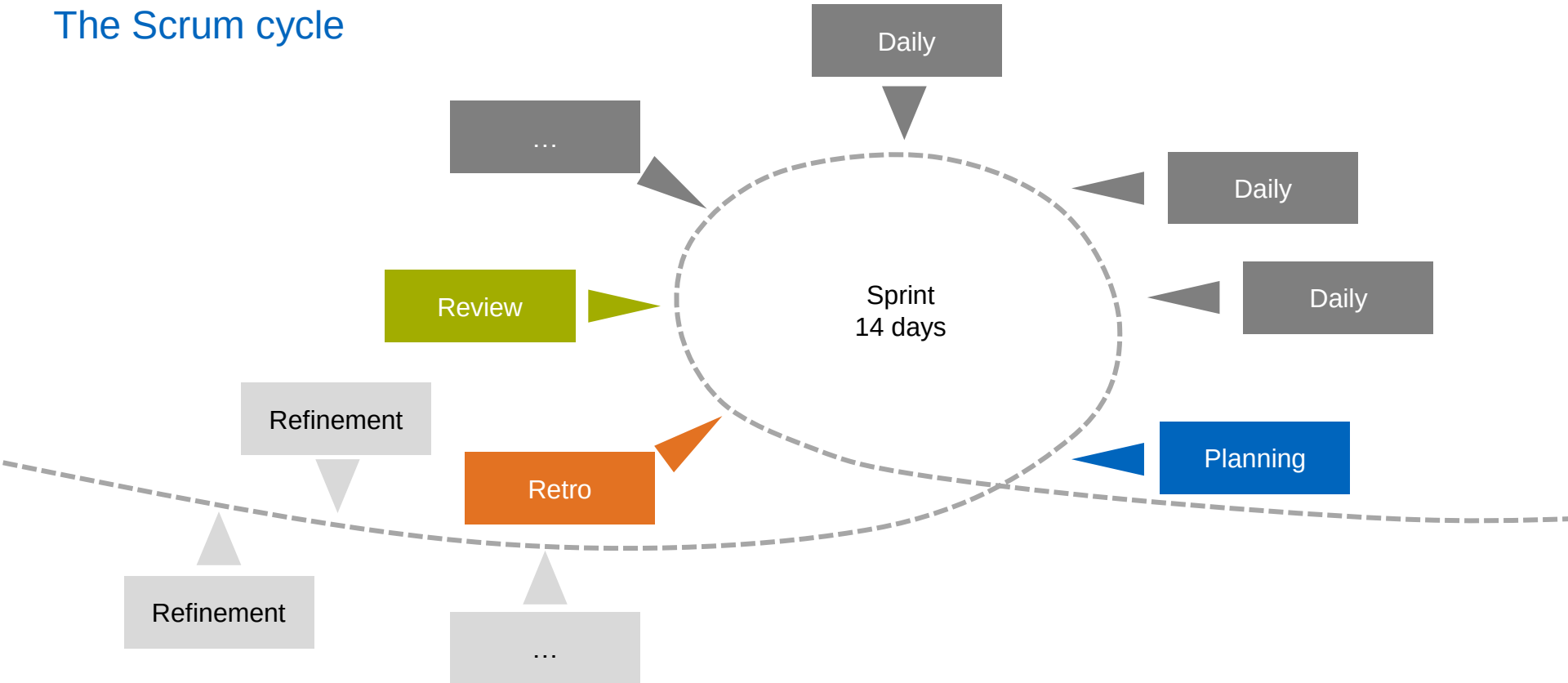
Product Goal
Product Backlog
Sprint Goal
Sprint Backlog
Product Increment

“The Scrum framework, as outlined herein, is immutable. While implementing only parts of Scrum is possible, the result is not Scrum. Scrum exists only in its entirety and functions well as a container for other techniques, methodologies, and practices.”

Schwaber, K., & Sutherland, J. (2020). The Scrum guide: The definitive guide to Scrum. <https://scrumguides.org/>

Scrum

The Scrum cycle



Scrum

Scrum is often supported through digital tools

Projects / Beyond Gravity

Board

⚡ ⌚ 4 days remaining Complete sprint ...

GROUP BY Choices ▾

TO DO 12

Implement feedback collector
NUC-205 9 ▾ 👤

Bump version for new API for billing
NUC-206 3 = 👤

Add NPS feedback to wallboard
NUC-208 1 > 👤

IN PROGRESS 4

Update T&C copy with v1.9 from the writers guild in all products that have cross country compliance
NUC-213 ⓘ 1 > 👤

Tech spike on new stripe integration with paypal
NUC-215 3 > 👤

Refactor stripe verification key validator to a single call to avoid timing out on slow connections
NUC-216 3 > 👤

Change phone number field type to 'phone'
NUC-217 ⓘ 1 > 👤

IN REVIEW 4

Multi-dest search UI web
NUC-338 5 > 👤

DONE 4

Quick booking for accomodations - web
NUC-336 ✓ ⓘ 4 > 👤

Adapt web app no new payments provider
NUC-346 ✓ ⓘ 3 ▾ 👤

Fluid booking on tablets
NUC-343 ✓ 5 = 👤

Shoping cart purchasing error - quick fix required.
NUC-354 ✓ 1 > 👤

<https://www.atlassian.com/de/software/jira/features/scrum-boards>

Scrum

Scaling Scrum up

- Scaling becomes necessary when several teams work on one product.
- It also becomes necessary when teams share technical dependencies or product priorities conflict.
- Integrated customer solutions, interdependencies, and compliance requirements increase coordination needs.
- Scaling frameworks address coordination beyond one team.



Image source: ChatGPT

Scrum

The challenge of scaling up: the case company

- **Company:** medium-sized high tech manufacturing company.
- **Products:** automated machines (e.g., laser welding battery packs).

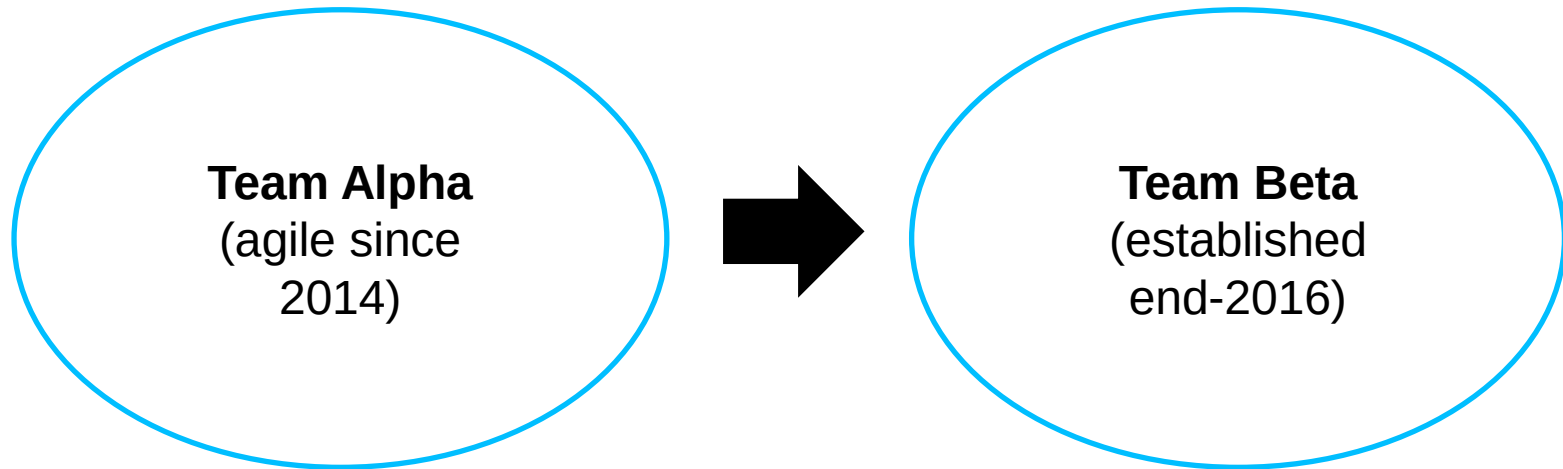


Mahringer, C. A., & Danner-Schröder, A. (2025). Autonomous, yet interdependent: Designing interfaces across routine clusters. *Academy of Management Journal*, 68(6), 1300 - 1327

Scrum

Scaling from one agile team to two agile team

Both teams were proximal.



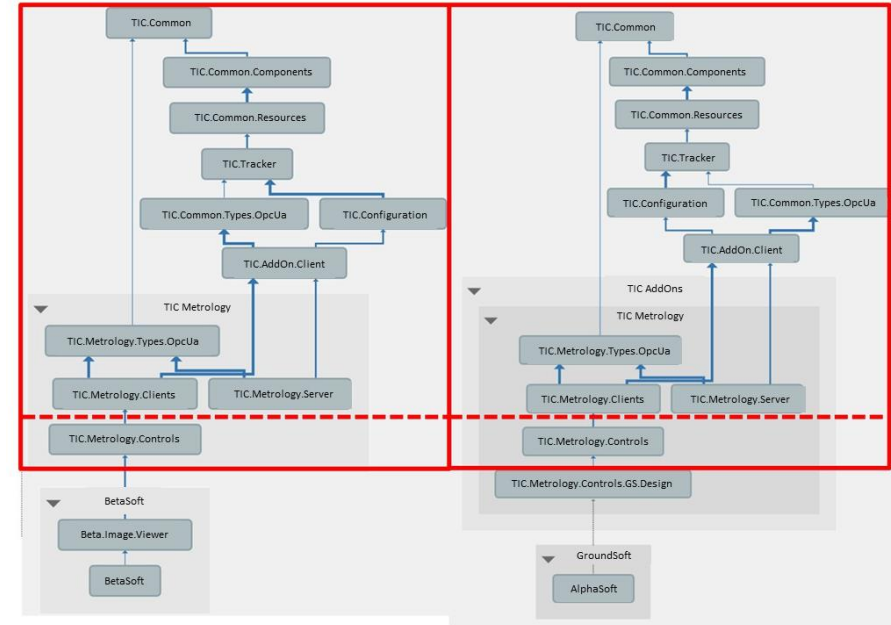
Mahringer, C. A., & Danner-Schröder, A. (2025). Autonomous, yet interdependent: Designing interfaces across routine clusters. *Academy of Management Journal*, 68(6), 1300 - 1327

Scrum

Four practices of scaling up

Practice 1: Analyzing Interdependencies

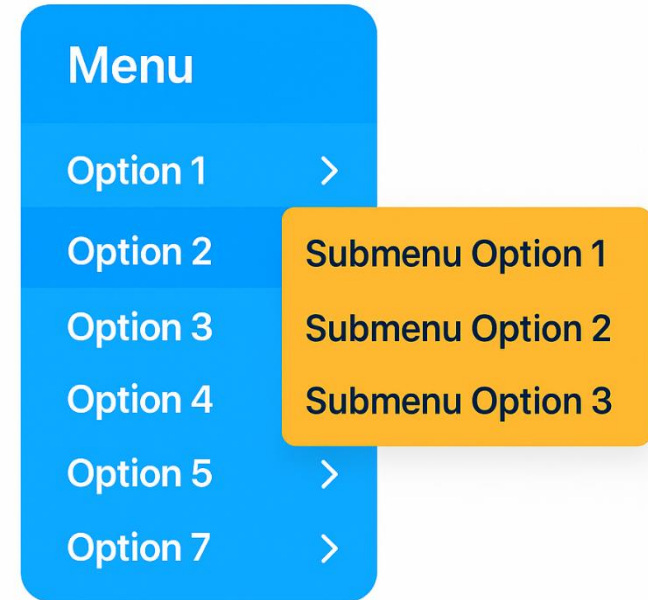
- **Explanation:** Identify how tasks, people, or technical components depend on one another.
- **Example:** Create a map showing which software components are shared across two development teams.



Four practices of scaling up

Practice 2: Reconfiguring Resources

- **Explanation:** Modify shared resources so that multiple teams can use them in parallel.
- **Example:** Adapt software components so they can be flexibly shared and used by both teams.

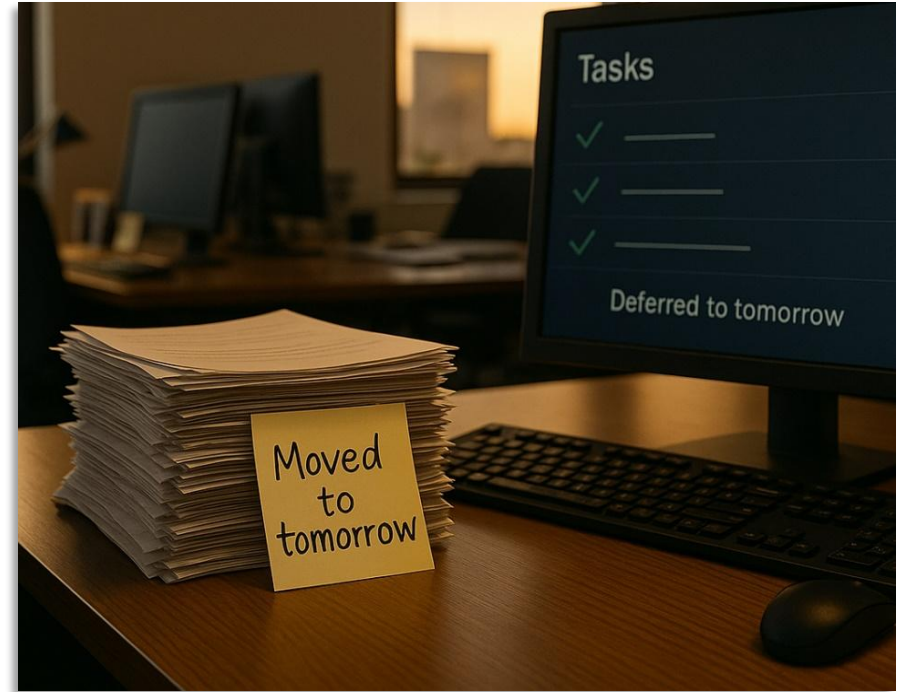


Scrum

Four practices of scaling up

Practice 3: Mitigating Interferences

- **Explanation:** Buffer disruptions that arise from using other competencies.
- **Example:** One team postpones tasks that depend on the other team's ongoing configuration of shared software code.



Mahringer, C. A., & Danner-Schröder, A. (2025). Autonomous, yet interdependent: Designing interfaces across routine clusters. *Academy of Management Journal*, 68(6), 1300 – 1327; Image source: ChatGPT

Scrum

Four practices of scaling up

Practice 4: Reconfiguring Schedules

- **Explanation:** Adjust the timing of resource use so that multiple teams can access shared resources.
- **Example:** The teams stagger their work rhythms so that a key person can participate in meetings in both teams.



Mahringer, C. A., & Danner-Schröder, A. (2025). Autonomous, yet interdependent: Designing interfaces across routine clusters. *Academy of Management Journal*, 68(6), 1300 – 1327; Image source: ChatGPT

Scrum

Is Scrum a new form of organizing?

Task:

- Apply the four-problem canvas to this organization:
 - How is work divided?
 - How is work allocated?
 - Why do people contribute?
 - How is information provided?
- Which aspects (if any) are new?
- Create one [slide](#).

Goal:

- Deepen your understanding of whether Scrum is a new form of organizing.

Modus:

- Group work.



Image source: ChatGPT

Scrum

What are the pros and cons of Scrum?



Image source: ChatGPT

Modern organizational forms

Network organization

Holocracy

Scrum

Design thinking

OKR

Design thinking

What is design thinking?

- A user-centered method for solving problems and developing new ideas.
- Starts with a problem or challenge.
- Focuses on user needs.
- Works through collaborative workshops.
- Uses iteration, visualization, and early testing.

Design thinking

The design thinking process



https://youtu.be/_r0VX-aU_T8?si=LevJ7WMwiWcMLDF5

Design thinking

Is design thinking a new form of organizing?

Task:

- Apply the four-problem canvas to this organization:
 - How is work divided?
 - How is work allocated?
 - Why do people contribute?
 - How is information provided?
- Which aspects (if any) are new?
- Create one [slide](#).

Goal:

- Deepen your understanding of whether design thinking is a new form of organizing.

Modus:

- Group work.



Image source: ChatGPT

Design thinking

What are the pros and cons of design thinking?



Image source: ChatGPT

Modern organizational forms

Network organization

Holocracy

Scrum

Design thinking

OKR

Why OKR? Strategy implementation under dynamic conditions

- Organizations often struggle with strategy implementation.
- Classic planning becomes problematic when the environment is dynamic.
- OKR translates strategic intent into a short, visible cycle of priorities and measurable progress.
- The method is useful when strategic direction exists but execution needs alignment and learning.

Core logic of OKR

Objective

- Describes a future state
("Where do we want to be?")
- Provides direction and focus.
- Should be qualitative, understandable, and meaningful.
- Connects team effort to strategy or value creation.

Key Results

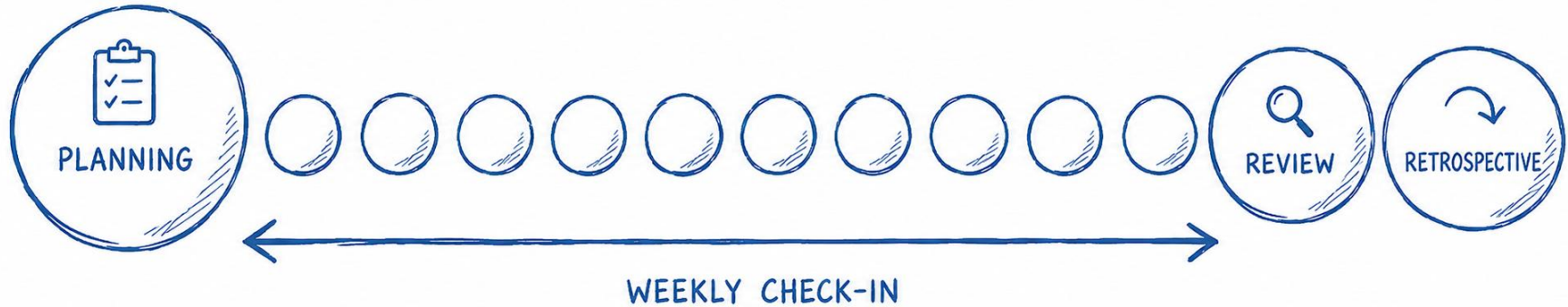
- Defines how progress is recognized.
("How do I know, that I am there?")
- Should be measurable and outcome oriented.
- Works as a lever for the objective.
- Usually two to four key results per objective.

OKR

The OKR process

OKR CYCLE

3-4 MONTHS



OKR

How OKR can be used to manage the organization

Corporate OKRs

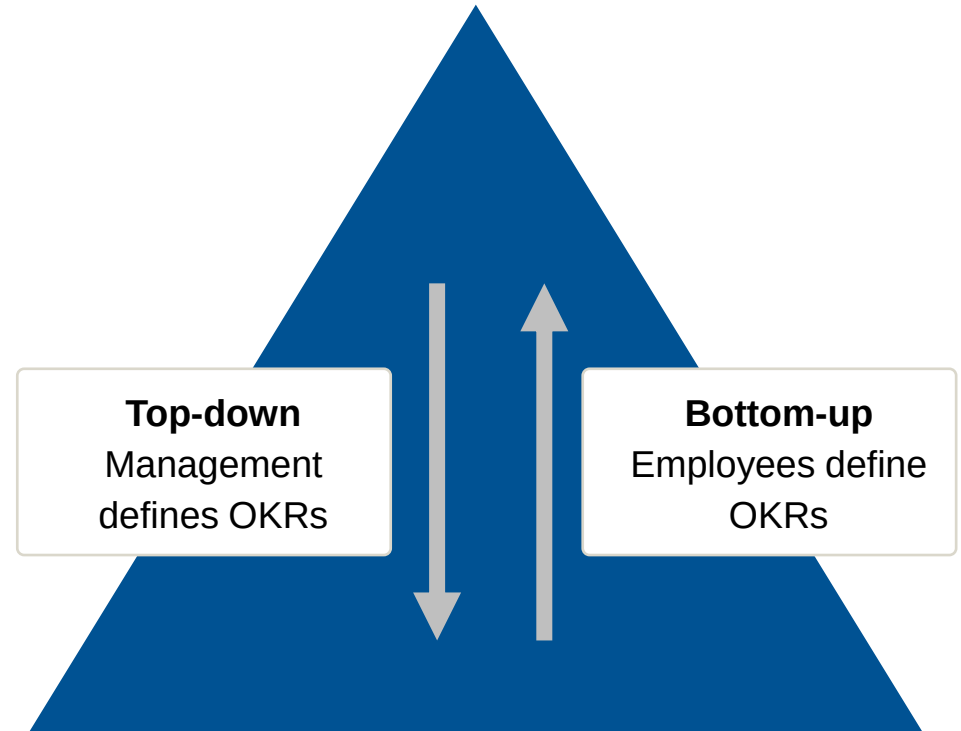
Apply for the entire organization

Department and team OKRs

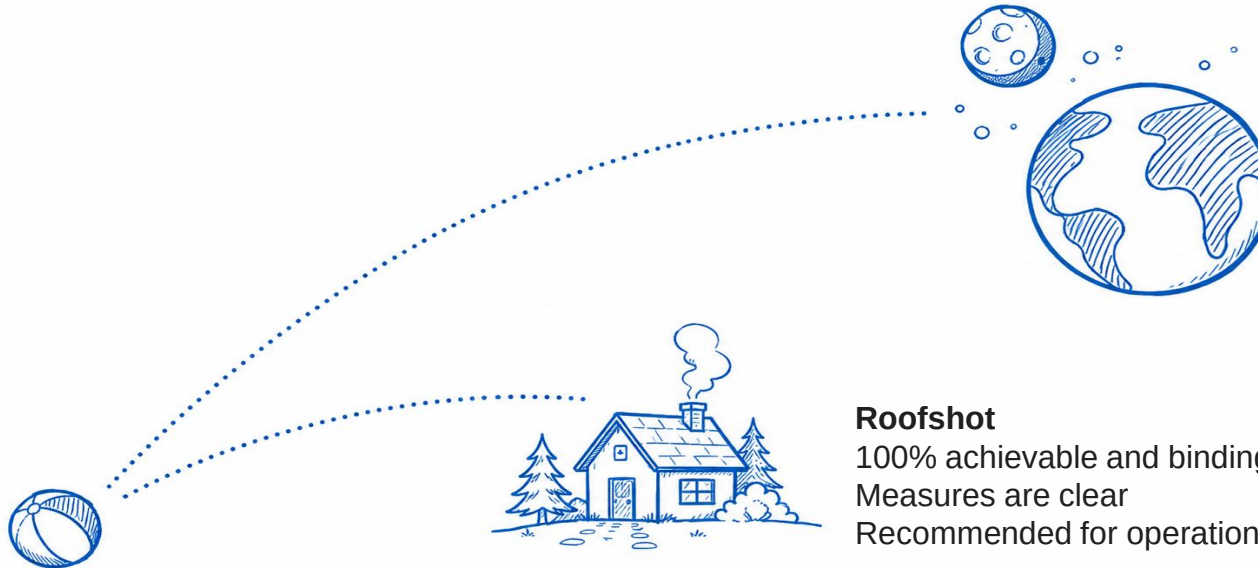
Manage priorities of subunits

Tasks

Based on priorities from OKRs



Roof shots versus moon shots



Moonshot

Success at 60 to 70%
already counts as progress
Encourages new solutions
Recommended for innovation

Roofshot

100% achievable and binding
Measures are clear
Recommended for operations

Are OKR a new form of organizing?

Task:

- Apply the four-problem canvas to this organization:
 - How is work divided?
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Goal:

- Deepen your understanding of whether OKR is a new form of organizing.

Modus:

- Group work.



Image source: ChatGPT

OKR

What are the pros and cons of OKR?



Image source: ChatGPT

Takeaways from today

Scrum is a prototypical agile framework that splits work into sprints.

While Scrum works well on the team level, scaling it is a challenge.

Design thinking is used to ideate new designs, which helps spark innovation.

OKR connects local work to strategy by focusing on objectives and key results.

I hope you enjoyed learning about organization theory!

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Contact information



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TUM School of Management,
Campus Heilbronn

christian.mahringer@bwi.uni-stuttgart.de

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